Differences Between Chinese and Western Workplaces

Company Culture

West: bosses allow banter and let staff manage their own time.

West: music, breaks, chat, and browsing are fine if work gets done.

West: deadlines are tight and things are expected to move fast.

China: more emphasis on protocol, respect for authority, and close bonds.

China: staff make the office feel like home — plants and personal items.

China: team lunches and formal team-building build a family feel.

China: business moves more slowly, with patience over speed.

Roles and Responsibilities

West: roles are clearly defined and handed to each person.

West: each person finishes their own tasks and shows their own ability.

West: helping outside your area can look like "stepping on toes".

China: your role often stretches beyond your job description.

China: your boss decides what extra work you take on.

China: everyone pitches in — it shows commitment to the job.

Overtime

West: hours are flexible as long as the work gets done.

West: most people head home at 5 or 6 p.m.

West: extra hours are paid back in pay, time off, or flexi-time.

China: leaving right at the end of the day is unusual.

China: many stay late, unpaid, to show willing and impress the boss.

Tardiness

West: being late can usually be made up at the end of the day.

West: repeat offenders get a few warnings before real action.

China: punctuality is a key sign of commitment.

China: some companies dock pay each time you're late.

Hierarchy and Layout

West: flatter structures and an "open door" to managers.

West: you can raise work or personal problems with your manager.

China: many layers, and pay grade shapes who has power.

China: the more senior the person, the less often you see them.

China: staff rarely joke with or share personal life with superiors.

Meetings

West: quick, informal meetings to spark ideas.

West: coffee-shop meetings, stand-ups, even plank meetings.

West: everyone gives feedback, whatever their level.

China: meetings are formal, official business (开会).

China: expect minutes, a big agenda, and a long block of time.

China: senior staff lead the talk; others speak only when asked.

Relationships

Build business relationships slowly, after people get to know you.

Contact usually comes face to face, not by phone or email.

"Guanxi" — good relationships — matters more than a quick deal.

Workers are expected to be friendly with the boss and socialize after work.

Keep business and social life separate; don't talk business at meals.

Greetings and Communication

Bow or nod; only shake hands if a hand is offered.

Use formal titles and surnames when you address people.

Applause is common when greeting a crowd.

Book appointments in advance.

Avoid staring into someone's eyes — it can seem disrespectful.

Behavior

Be on time; arriving late is an insult.

Avoid big hand movements.

Don't point with your index finger — use an open palm.

Avoid physical contact, like patting a colleague on the back.

Clothing

Dress conservatively and simply.

Men: dark suits and dark, formal ties.

Women: suits or dresses with a high neckline.

Low or flat heels are preferred over high heels.

Avoid bright colors.